Understanding task instructions

Practical guide for students | D01-ST

1. Identify the action **1**
2. Check how to work **1**
3. Identify the expected result **1**
4. Use the example **1**
5. Ask a specific question **1**
6. Check your first attempt **1**

Before starting a classroom task, check what you need to do. You do not need to understand every word, but you do need to understand the main actions and expected result.

1. Identify the action

Look or listen for words that tell you what to do, such as *choose*, *compare*, *discuss*, *calculate* or *explain*. Check what you should do first and what comes next.

2. Check how to work

Are you working alone, with a partner or in a group? What should **each** person contribute?

3. Identify the expected result

What should you have ready at the end: an answer, a diagram, a written explanation or a spoken report? Check how much time you have.

4. Use the example

If your teacher demonstrates the task, notice the steps and the type of response expected. Apply those steps to your own work.

5. Ask a specific question

Explain which part you understand and which part you need clarified:

- "Do we choose one option or compare both?"
- "Should we write our answers or prepare to explain them?"
- "I understand the first step. What do we do after that?"
- "Could you show us an example?"

6. Check your first attempt

After beginning, compare your work with the instructions or example. If you are unsure, show your teacher what you have done and ask whether you are approaching the task correctly.

Example

Instruction: “Work in pairs. Compare the two graphs and agree on the main difference. Be ready to explain your answer.”

What I need to do

- Work with one partner.
- Examine both graphs.
- Discuss and agree on the main difference.
- Prepare to explain our answer.

A useful clarification question

“Do we need to describe every difference, or choose the most important one?”

Before you start

- I know the main action.
- I know who I am working with.
- I know what we need to produce.
- I know how much time we have.
- I have asked about anything that prevents me from starting.

If you are still unsure: ask your teacher to explain the unclear step in a different way or demonstrate it. You can show your understanding by saying, “So, first we … Is that right?”

Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). *Understanding your assignment*. Learning Lab. https://learninglab.rmit.edu.au/assessments/getting-started-with-assignments/understanding-your-assignment/

Supports identifying instruction words, checking task requirements and using a checklist. Guidance about assignments has been adapted here for classroom tasks.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Listening*. https://ccaps.umn.edu/esl-resources/students/listening

Supports asking specific clarification questions, checking your interpretation and requesting further explanation or an example. See “While Listening”.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing and Professional Studies. (n.d.). *Participating in class*. https://ccaps.umn.edu/esl-resources/students/speaking/participating

Supports asking teachers to explain further, clarify meaning or provide an example. See “Asking Questions in Class”.

The task example, checklist and classroom-specific question prompts were developed for this toolkit. The six-step sequence is a toolkit adaptation; these sources support particular elements rather than the complete sequence.